

System Design Interview Mindset

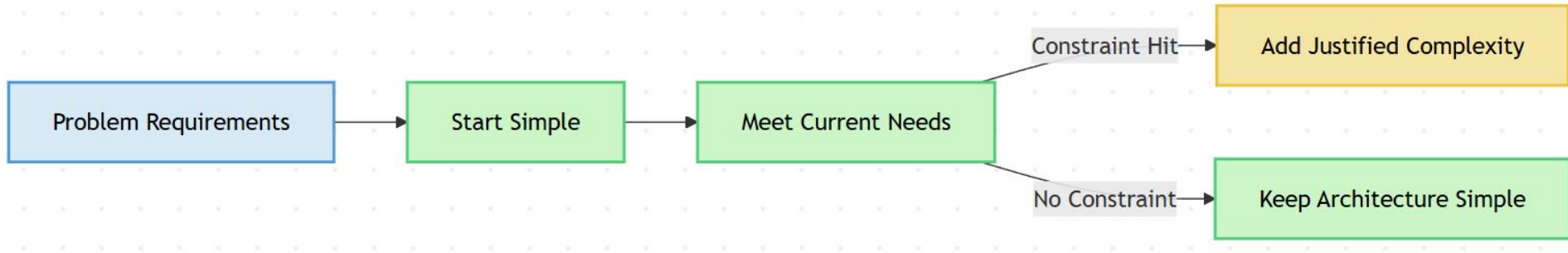
System Design Crash Course: Quick Revision Before Interviews

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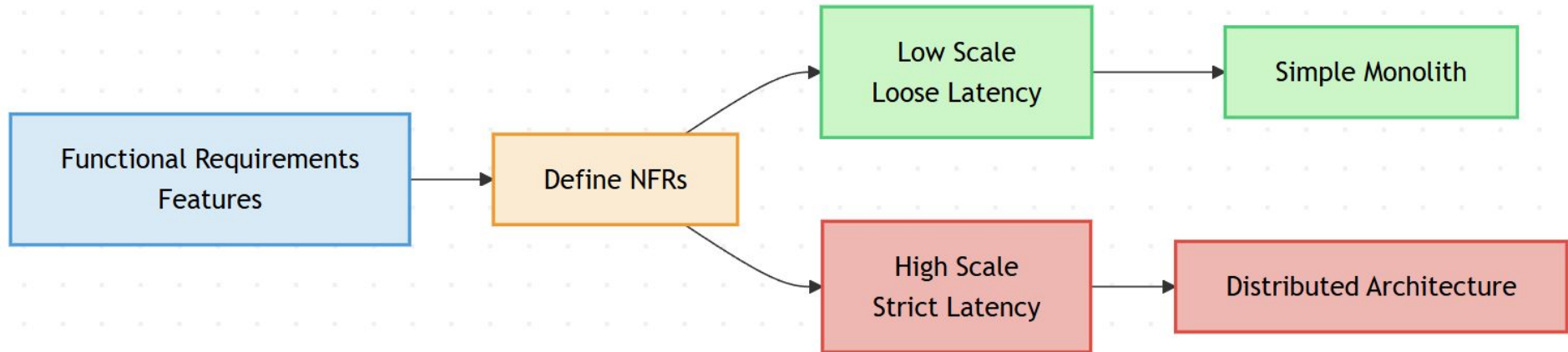
What “Good Design” Means in Interviews

- Solves requirements, not hypothetical futures
- Simple first, complexity justified later
- Clear trade-offs, not fancy components
- Scales when needed, not by default
- Easy to explain and reason about



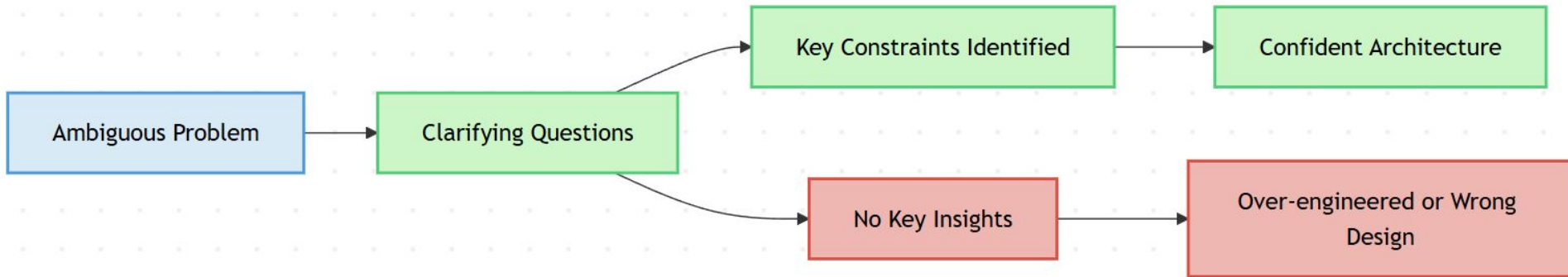
Functional vs Non-Functional Requirements

- Functional = what system does
- NFRs = how system behaves
- NFRs shape architecture choices
- Same features, different architectures
- Clarify NFRs before designing



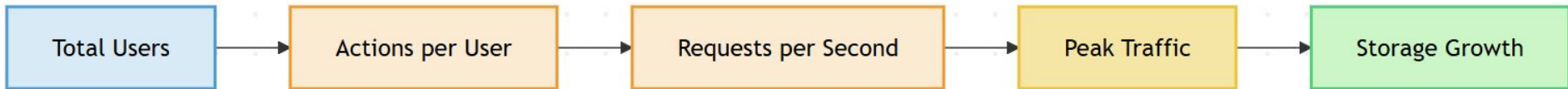
Asking Clarifying Questions Effectively

- Clarify scope before designing
- Ask constraint-revealing questions
- Prioritize NFRs early
- Avoid implementation-level questions
- Questions signal seniority



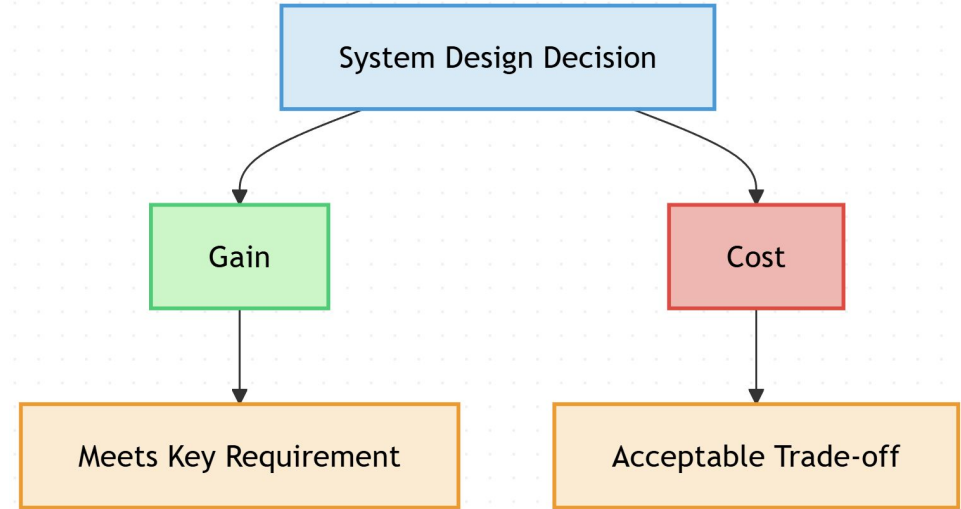
Capacity Estimation Using Rough Math

- Estimate orders, not exact numbers
- Users → traffic → storage flow
- Think in per-second metrics
- Peak load matters most
- Assumptions stated, then adjusted



The Golden Rule of System Design Interviews

- No perfect system exists
- Every choice has a cost
- Optimize for stated requirements
- Trade-offs > fancy solutions
- Justify decisions explicitly



The Think-Aloud Strategy

- Speak your reasoning continuously
- Silence hides good thinking
- Narration beats fast answers
- Explain choices, not conclusions
- Course-correct openly

